Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation

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Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation

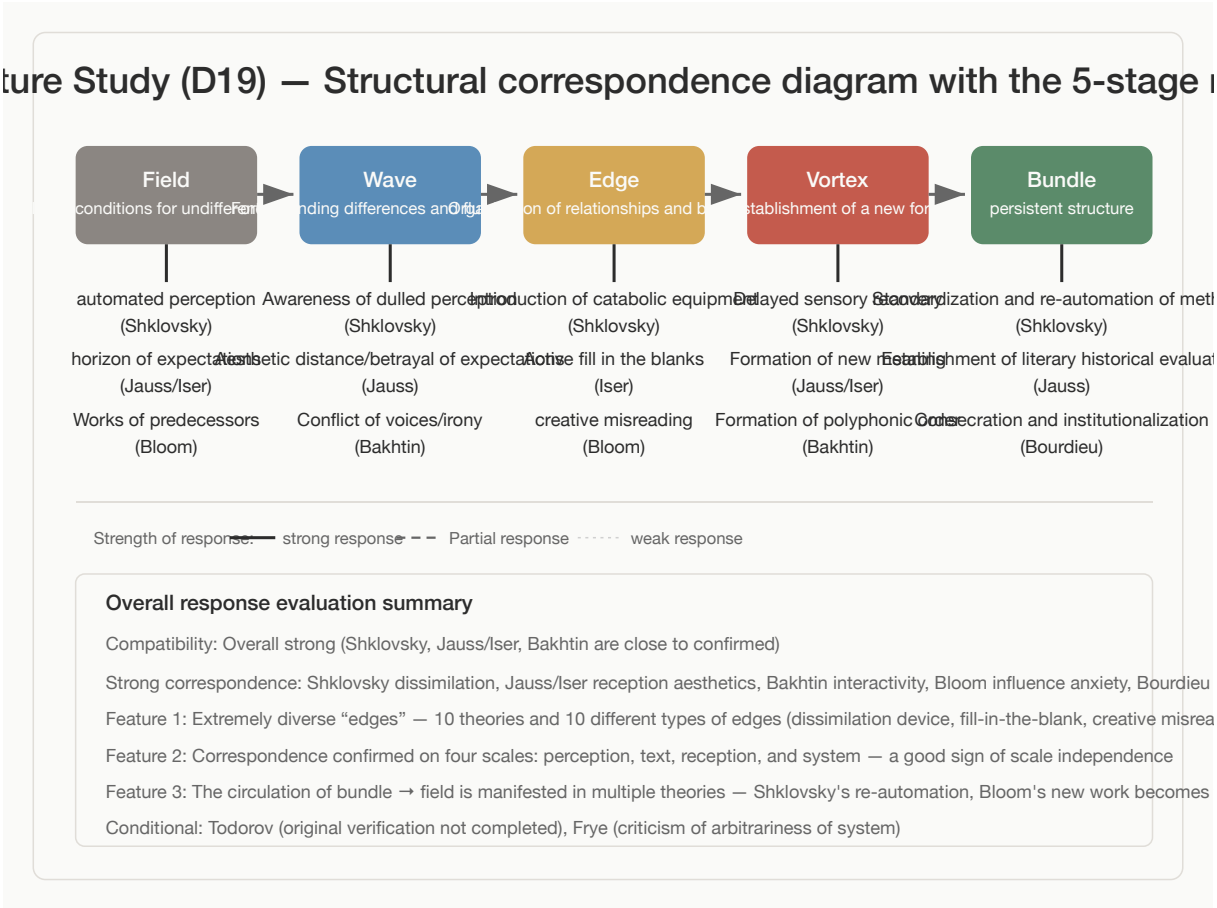

Figure 1: Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation — Structural correspondence diagram

1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation

This report presents the results of an investigation into the following question, using major theoretical systems in literary studies.

> Do the theories of this academic domain correspond structurally to the five-stage model, Field -> Wave -> Edge -> Vortex -> Bundle?

Literary studies is a discipline that describes the generation of works, transformation of perception, reception, and institutionalization across multiple scales. Why do narratives often take similar structural forms? Why are works that violate expectation so often valued highly? How does what is left unsaid generate meaning? The purpose of this investigation is to examine whether existing literary theories correspond structurally to the five-stage model.

This document is a report of findings. It is neither a textbook of literary theory nor a proof of the five-stage model. It reports both places where correspondence was confirmed and places where it was not, with the same level of restraint.

2. Method of Investigation

In this investigation, ten theories were selected from literary studies.

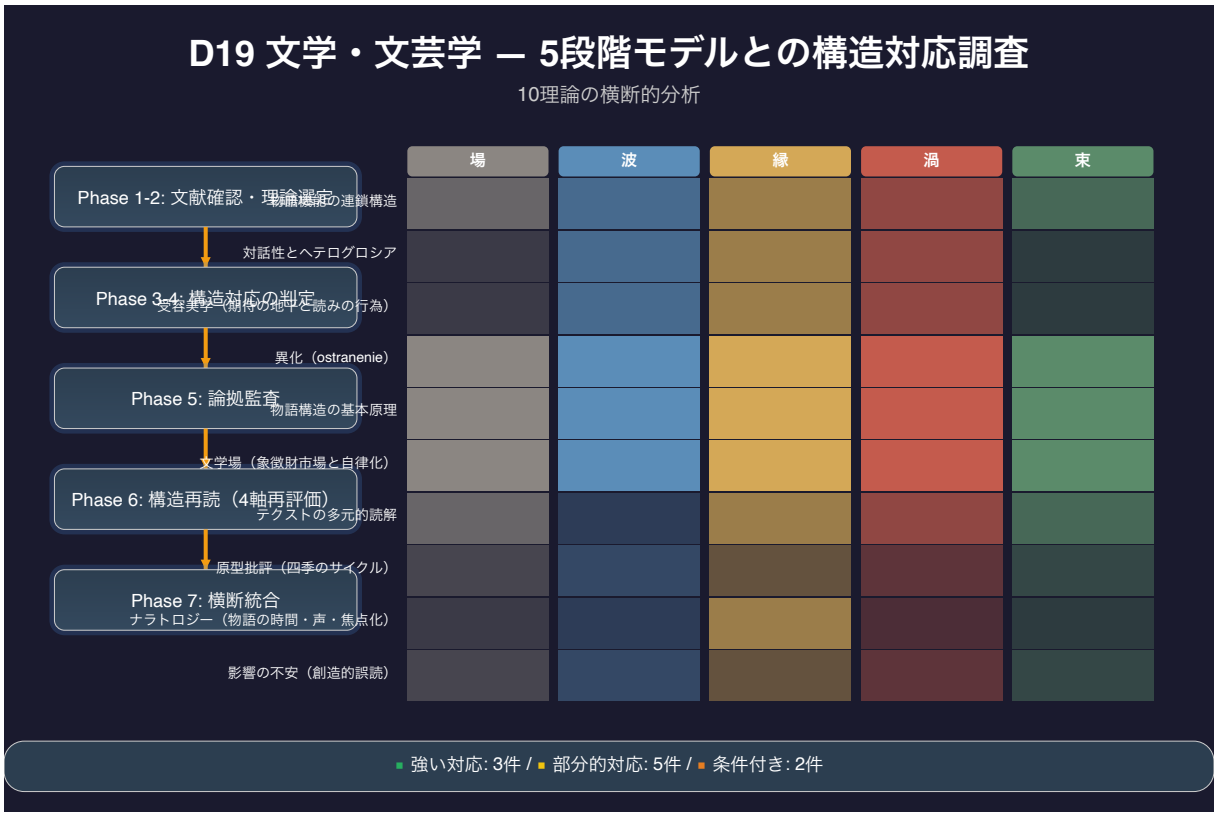

Figure 2: Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation —

Selection criteria: The set was designed to cover three evaluation lenses. First, the relation between creation and reception, the dynamics of author, text, and reader. Second, the dialectic of deviation and norm, including defamiliarization, violation of expectation, and renewal of genre. Third, the connection between internal textual structure and social institution. The set includes Russian formalism, French structuralism and post-structuralism, reception aesthetics, archetypal criticism, influence theory, sociology of literature, and dialogism.

Method of evaluation: For each theory, structural correspondence with the five-stage model was examined from multiple independent perspectives, and the strength of correspondence was then judged. Concretely, the analysis asked whether each phase described by the theory corresponds qualitatively to one of Field, Wave, Edge, Vortex, or Bundle.

Criteria of judgment: When the phases of a theory correspond qualitatively to the five stages and the logic of transition between stages remains coherent, the theory was judged to show strong structural correspondence. When only some stages corresponded clearly, the theory was treated as partial. When conditions remained, such as incomplete primary-text verification, the theory was treated as conditional.

Limits of the investigation: This investigation examines whether structural correspondence is present. It does not claim causal relation or identity of origin. In addition, one theory, Todorov, remains incompletely checked against the primary text, so its judgment remains provisional.

3. Overview of the Five-Stage Model

The five-stage model describes creative process through the following five stages.

Field: An undifferentiated condition. It is the initial state in which neither direction nor structure has yet been fixed.

Wave: A stage of exploration in which multiple directions diverge and compete. Difference becomes visible and fluctuation appears.

Edge: A tense condition in which opposing elements coexist without converging into either side. Whether a process can remain at this stage bears on the quality of creation.

Vortex: A stage in which a new coherence or order rises spontaneously out of the tension.

Bundle: A stage in which form is fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure. Bundle becomes the precondition for the next Field, and the cycle continues.

The five stages do not form a straight line but a cycle. Return from Bundle to Field, the way in which generated structure becomes the precondition for the next creation, is what allows the process to continue. The five stages are also not limited to one scale, but may appear from individual cognition to organizational change and historical institutional transformation.

If these definitions already feel uncomfortable, that discomfort is itself important for the investigation. It may be meaningful either to continue while holding onto it or to pause at this point.

4. Results: Overall Picture

Figure 3: Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation — ×5

The investigation of ten theories found structural correspondence with the five-stage model in nine cases, while one remained conditional.

Theory	Proponent	Strength of Correspondence	Distinctive Feature
Chain structure of narrative functions	Propp (1928)	Strong	Staged unfolding of narrative structure
Dialogism and heteroglossia	Bakhtin (1934-35)	Strong	Negotiation among many voices
Reception aesthetics	Jauss (1967) / Iser (1972)	Strong	Horizon of expectation and textual gaps
Defamiliarization	Shklovsky (1917)	Strong	Automatization and recovery of perception
Basic principles of narrative structure	Todorov (1971)	Conditional	Verification against the primary text remains incomplete
Literary field	Bourdieu (1971, 1992)	Strong	Institutional-level autonomization
Plural reading of the text	Barthes (1970)	Strong	Text as woven field of codes
Archetypal criticism	Frye (1957)	Strong	Cyclical structure of literary history
Narratology	Genette (1972)	Strong	Multi-layered structure of narrative discourse
Anxiety of influence	Bloom (1973)	Strong	Creative misreading

Literary studies is a domain with high structural correspondence to the five-stage model. Especially noteworthy is that Edge takes a different form in all ten theories. It appears as function type in Propp, dialogic type in Bakhtin, reception type in Jauss and Iser, perceptual type in Shklovsky, cognitive type in Todorov, institutional type in Bourdieu, code type in Barthes, modal type in Frye, focalization type in Genette, and misreading type in Bloom.

5. Results: Findings by Theory

5.1 Why Narratives Share Similar Structures: Propp

In *Morphology of the Folktale*, Propp broke Russian wonder tales into thirty-one functions. A function is a structural unit defined from the point of view of the tale as a whole. His crucial discovery was that the order of appearance of these functions remains invariant.

This chain of functions corresponds to the five-stage model as follows. Stable initial family or communal situation corresponds to Field. Lack, some absence, loss, or deprivation, corresponds to Wave as the force setting the story in motion. Encounters with donor and antagonist, where relation is woven, correspond to Edge. Formation of a new order through ordeal, struggle, and transformation corresponds to Vortex. Return, marriage, or the new kingdom as stability correspond to Bundle.

A caution is necessary. Compressing thirty-one functions into five stages inevitably loses information. Internal order relations among functions and branching or repeated structures, such as Propp's moves, are simplified in this coarse-graining. Structural correspondence is present, but the compression is heuristic rather than exact.

5.2 Seeing the Familiar as New: Shklovsky's Defamiliarization

Shklovsky argues that the purpose of art is to recover things not as already known but as acts of perception. Repetition in daily life automatizes perception and the world ceases to be genuinely noticed. Defamiliarization is the technique that makes the object strange again and prolongs the time of perception.

In terms of the five-stage model, habitualized perception, automatized condition, corresponds to Field. Awareness of automatization and dulling of perception corresponds to Wave. Introduction of a defamiliarizing device, the operation that sets a boundary between ordinary and poetic language, corresponds to Edge. The process by which the object rises again as newly perceived corresponds to Vortex. Sharing and normalization of the technique, followed by renewed pressure toward automatization, correspond to Bundle returning to Field.

This theory contributes a distinctive insight: where the five-stage model often describes generation of structure, defamiliarization describes recovery of perception. Creation is not only making something new, but also newly perceiving what was already there.

5.3 Why Value Rises When Expectation Is Broken: Jauss and Iser

Jauss introduced the horizon of expectation, the framework of anticipation formed by genre, prior works, and social context. A work's value is measured by its aesthetic distance from that horizon. Comfortable conformity has less force than the work that violates expectation and thereby renews literary history.

Iser introduced the concept of gaps, places intentionally left open in the text and actively completed by the reader. Meaning is not simply given by the author, but is generated when the reader fills those gaps.

The five-stage correspondence is as follows. Existing reader expectation and genre norm correspond to Field. Friction produced by a new work departing from expectation corresponds to Wave. Negotiation of meaning in criticism and reading, together with completion of textual gaps, corresponds to Edge. Formation of a new interpretive framework corresponds to Vortex. Institutionalization as literary-historical evaluation corresponds to Bundle. That stabilized evaluation then becomes the next horizon of expectation, a clear Bundle -> Field return.

This theory is distinctive because it makes the reader a subject of creation. Meaning is not given once and for all by the author. It is generated through the reader's completion of the text. This supports the view that Edge is not a one-way operation but a bidirectional relation.

5.4 All Creation Is Misreading: Bloom's Anxiety of Influence

Bloom argues that poets create under the pressure of predecessors, but establish originality by creatively misreading them. Influence is experienced as anxiety. He systematizes this process through six revisionary ratios.

The five-stage correspondence runs as follows. The works of predecessors constitute Field. Here Bundle becomes Field, because established structure becomes the precondition of the next creation. Anxiety of influence raises the desire for difference, corresponding to Wave. Creative misreading, through which the predecessor's text is selectively re-read and the relation to the predecessor redefined, corresponds to Edge. Emergence of a distinct work corresponds to Vortex. The new text then becomes Field for successors, corresponding to Bundle returning to Field.

This theory rests on the premise that complete originality is an illusion. All creation is response to predecessors, and something new arises by rejecting the correct reading and taking up the wrong reading instead. In that respect, Bloom resonates deeply with the dynamic logic of the

five-stage model. At the same time, the numerical mismatch between Bloom's six revisionary ratios and the model's five stages remains unresolved.

5.5 Dialogism and Many-Voiced Language: Bakhtin

Bakhtin describes the novel as a site of heteroglossia, a socially stratified plurality of languages in negotiation and conflict. Dialogism means that every utterance responds to other utterances and already includes them. Monologic language is only an artificial suppression of this dialogic condition. Through carnival, Bakhtin also describes temporary inversion of official order and tension between authoritative discourse and internally persuasive discourse.

The five-stage correspondence is as follows. A heteroglossic space in which different social languages coexist corresponds to Field. Visibility of difference through conflict among voices and irony corresponds to Wave. The scene in which different voices cross and discourse is joined relationally corresponds to Edge. Formation of an internally ordered polyphonic work corresponds to Vortex. Incorporation into the literary system as genre convention corresponds to Bundle.

Bakhtin gives one of the strongest language-philosophical foundations for Edge. If every utterance is an answer to another utterance, then Edge is always woven dialogically.

5.6 The Technique of Not Saying: Barthes and Genette

Barthes reads the text as a weave of five codes, hermeneutic, proairetic, semic, symbolic, and cultural. He distinguishes readerly texts from writerly texts, arguing that the latter turn the reader into a producer of meaning rather than a consumer of already fixed meaning. Through the thesis of the death of the author, he also insists that the meaning of the text cannot be reduced to authorial intention.

Genette constructs a system for analyzing narrative discourse through categories of time, mood, and voice. Especially important is focalization, the distinction between who speaks and who sees. Zero focalization does not restrict information, internal focalization limits the account to one figure's perspective, and external focalization withholds interior access.

In correspondence with the five-stage model, both theorists describe the multilayered character of Edge within the text. Barthes's five codes describe a structure in which multiple layers of meaning intersect and weave together, a multilayered implementation of Edge. Genette's focalization is a design of what is shown and what is not shown, and therefore a description of Edge as formed among narrator, story, and reader.

The writerly text, the text that does not fix meaning in advance, makes creative participation by the reader possible. The structure in which meaning arises because the text does not say everything is both a distinctively literary finding and one concrete form of Edge.

5.7 Universality of Narrative Structure: Todorov

Todorov argues that the basic conditions of narrative are succession and transformation. Succession alone yields only chronicle; narrative appears when transformation is involved. A new equilibrium is the same as the initial one, but not identical to it.

The widely circulated sequence equilibrium -> disruption -> recognition -> response -> new equilibrium is striking in its correspondence with the five-stage model. Equilibrium corresponds to Field as undifferentiated stability. Breakdown corresponds to Wave as the visibility of difference. Recognition corresponds to Edge as problem formulation and relational organization. Response corresponds to Vortex as the organization of action. New equilibrium corresponds to Bundle as stabilized order including transformation. The fact that the ending is the same but not identical also matches the spiral return from Bundle to Field.

At the same time, because it remains unverified in the present investigation whether Todorov explicitly lists these five elements in the primary text, this case remains conditional.

5.8 Frye's Archetypal Criticism: The Seasons of Literature

Frye proposes four major mythoi, comedy, romance, tragedy, and irony or satire, and also describes five literary modes. Literary history itself appears as a cycle, moving from one dominant mode to another.

In relation to the five-stage model, the mythic mode can be read as Field, romance as Wave, high mimetic as Edge, low mimetic as Vortex, and irony as Bundle, followed by return from the extreme of irony toward myth again. Extreme self-consciousness, in this reading, drives return toward a new innocence.

This theory suggests that the five-stage model may correspond not only to individual creative acts but also to literary history at large. At the same time, mapping four mythoi and five modes onto five stages necessarily involves compression, and criticism of arbitrariness remains legitimate.

5.9 The Social Institution of Literature: Bourdieu

Bourdieu's theory of the literary field describes literature as becoming autonomous through a process of differentiation from external powers such as aristocracy, church, and market. The field is structured through the opposition between restricted production, production for producers, and large-scale production, production for the general public. Consecration, recognition within the field, legitimates and institutionalizes value.

The correspondence with the five-stage model is as follows. Cultural production still dominated by external constraint corresponds to Field. Tension between internal and external legitimacy under market expansion and enlargement of publics corresponds to Wave. Organization of the relation network formed by publishers, critics, education, and consecrating institutions corresponds to Edge. Autonomous emergence of restricted production corresponds to Vortex. Institutionalization through consecration and reproduction corresponds to Bundle.

Bourdieu is distinctive because, unlike entries focusing on textual structure or reader-text relation, he describes the emergence of the literary field itself at institutional scale. He therefore confirms that the five-stage model may correspond across levels from textual microstructure to social macrostructure.

6. Cross-Domain Patterns

6.1 The Many Forms of Edge

The most striking finding of the present investigation is that all ten theories implement Edge in different forms. Propp describes it as functional encounter. Bakhtin as dialogic crossing of voices. Jauss and Iser as negotiation of meaning and completion of gaps. Shklovsky as insertion of the defamiliarizing device. Todorov as recognition and formulation of the problem. Bourdieu as institutional network. Barthes as crossing of codes. Frye as modal and social constraint. Genette as focalization. Bloom as creative misreading.

This diversity suggests that Edge is defined not by one fixed form but by a structural feature: opposing elements coexist in unresolved tension. This is the same broader pattern found in sociology with its many forms of Edge.

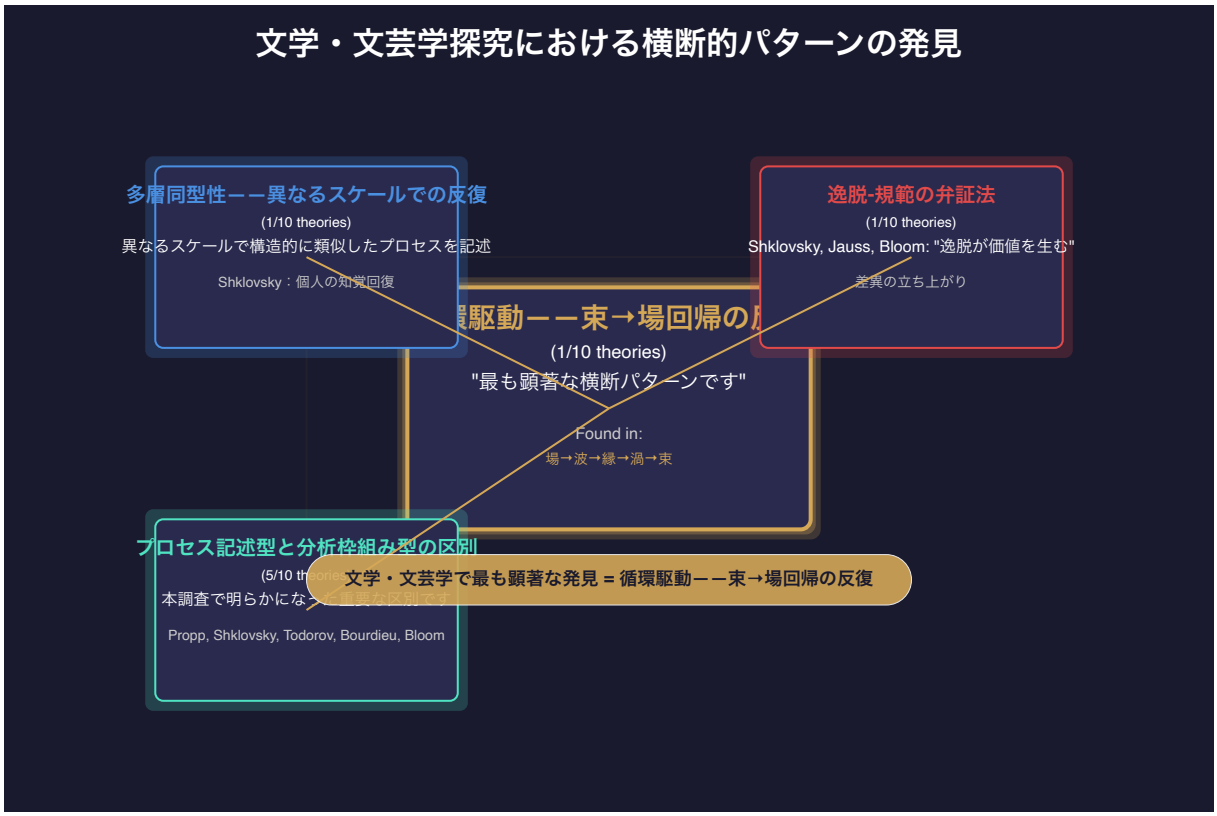

Figure 4: Literary Studies: Narrative Structure and the Five Stages of Creation —

6.2 The Bundle -> Field Cycle

Several theories independently describe return from Bundle to Field. Shklovsky gives the cycle defamiliarization -> normalization -> renewed defamiliarization. Bloom gives predecessor -> anxiety of influence -> creative misreading -> new text. Frye gives cyclical literary history. Jauss gives the renewal of the horizon of expectation. In all of these, a stabilized structure becomes the precondition for the next creation.

This cycle is especially clear in literature. Technique stabilizes through normalization, but the very moment of stability creates the need for new deviation. Shklovsky's theory of defamiliarization is the most direct statement of this pattern.

6.3 A Structure in Which Deviation Produces Value

A literary pattern of particular importance is that deviation itself carries positive value. Shklovsky's defamiliarization, Jauss's aesthetic distance, and Bloom's creative misreading all describe departure from the existing norm as the source of literary value.

This corresponds closely to the role of Wave in the five-stage model, where the visible emergence of difference drives the process of creation. Literature is a domain that organizes deviation not as something to be suppressed, but as something to be valued.

6.4 Creation as Recovery of Perception

Shklovsky's theory suggests that creation can mean not only making something new, but perceiving something known in a new way. This expands the scope of the five-stage model beyond the generation of structure toward transformation of perception itself, which is a distinctive contribution of literary studies.

7. Unresolved Questions

The following questions remain unresolved.

The nature of correspondence between Todorov's five elements and the five-stage model: Is the sequence equilibrium -> disruption -> recognition -> response -> new equilibrium structurally necessary, or only accidentally similar in number? Verification against the primary text is still needed.

The hypothesis that all creation is narrative: If the basic structure of narrative and the basic structure of creation are isomorphic, creativity and narrativity may share the same deep form. The scope and limit of that hypothesis require further examination.

The numerical mismatch between Bloom's six revisionary ratios and the five stages: A methodological problem remains concerning how those six ratios are to be compressed or integrated.

The distinction between generation of analysis and generation of being: Many literary theories describe how understanding of a work is generated, as in Barthes, Genette, and Jauss or Iser. The five-stage model, by contrast, often describes how a work as an existent comes into being. Bloom approaches the latter, but more text-analytic theories remain closer to the former. The effect of this difference of level on structural correspondence requires further consideration.

8. Conclusion

Literary studies is a domain with high structural correspondence to the five-stage model. Of the ten theories investigated, nine showed strong structural correspondence and one remained conditional.

Three findings are especially important.

First, all ten theories implement Edge in different forms. This supports the idea that Edge is defined not by one concrete morphology but by the structural feature of unresolved tension among opposed elements.

Second, return from Bundle to Field was independently confirmed in several theories, especially Shklovsky, Bloom, Frye, and Jauss. Literature stabilizes through norm formation, but the very moment of stabilization creates the need for the next deviation.

Third, the distinctively literary structure in which deviation generates value resonates deeply with the dynamic principle of the five-stage model. Shklovsky's theory of defamiliarization in particular suggests that the scope of the five-stage model may include not only generation of structure but also transformation of perception.

At the same time, confirmation of structural correspondence is not proof of causal relation. Structural similarity between literary theory and the five-stage model has been confirmed, but the question of what that similarity ultimately derives from, whether from a universal structure of creative process or from patterns common to theoretical construction itself, remains beyond the scope of the present investigation.